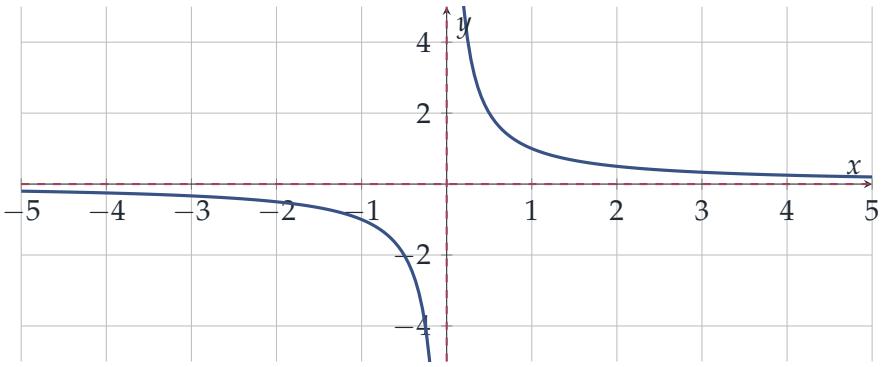
Chapter 4

Reciprocal (inverse) function

Skills: finding a domain, differentiating, studying a sign, drawing up a table of variations, graphing

4.1 Reference notes

The reciprocal function is defined by $f(x) = \dfrac{1}{x}$ on $\mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$.



Key points

$f'(x) = -\dfrac{1}{x^2} < 0$ for every $x \neq 0$. The reciprocal function is strictly decreasing on each of the intervals $]-\infty, 0[$ and $]0, +\infty[$. The lines $x = 0$ and $y = 0$ are asymptotes.

Common mistake

One cannot write that the reciprocal function is decreasing "on $\mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$" without specifying the two intervals. For example $-1 < 1$ but $f(-1) = -1 < 1 = f(1)$, which would contradict the global definition of decreasing.

For a function $g(x) = P(x) + \dfrac{k}{x}$, proceed in this order: domain; derivative; common denominator and factorisation; sign of the derivative; variations; limits or behaviour at the boundaries; useful points; graph.

Worked example

On $]0, +\infty[$, $g(x) = x + \dfrac{4}{x}$ satisfies $g'(x) = 1 - \dfrac{4}{x^2} = \dfrac{(x-2)(x+2)}{x^2}$. The denominator is positive; g' is negative on $]0, 2[$ then positive on $]2, +\infty[$. The function has a minimum $g(2) = 4$.

Session 23 — Definition and graph of the reciprocal function

Reciprocal (inverse) function

15 Dec 2026 • B: 2 h – C: 1 h

Session objectives

- Find the domain.
- Draw the curve.
- Use symmetries.

Fluency – 6 to 8 minutes, no calculator

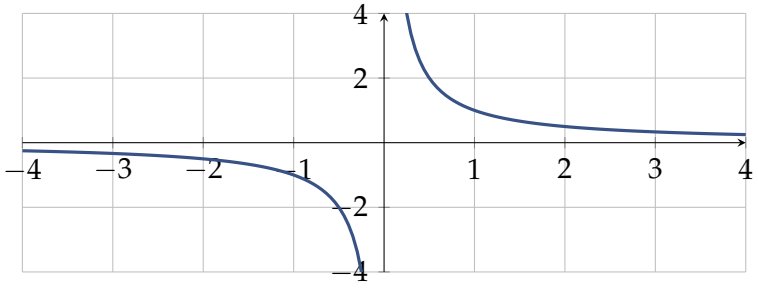
1. Simplify $3x + 5 - x + 2$. .....
2. Give the excluded value of $\dfrac{x+1}{x}$. .....
3. Calculate $\dfrac{1}{5}$ and $\dfrac{1}{-5}$. .....
4. Differentiate $3x^2 - 5x + 1$. .....
5. Solve $(x-2)(x+1) = 0$. .....

Reminder and prerequisites

Reread the last written record and be able to carry out the basic calculations needed today. Before the investigation, have students rephrase the key words: find the domain and draw the curve.

Investigation

Calculate $\dfrac{1}{x}$ for $x = -4, -2, -1, -\dfrac{1}{2}, \dfrac{1}{2}, 1, 2, 4$. Plot the points and describe the symmetries. Why is $x = 0$ missing?



Written record

The reciprocal function is $f(x) = \dfrac{1}{x}$ on $\mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$. Its curve is a hyperbola symmetric about the origin.

Worked example

Revisit the data from the investigation and write up the solution in order: definition of the objects, property used, exact or approximate calculation, then a concluding sentence. The model answer appears in the teacher edition.

Practice – essential

1. Give the domain and the asymptotes of $f(x) = 5 + \dfrac{7}{x}$.
2. Calculate $f'(x)$ and study its sign.
3. Study the function $g(x) = x + \dfrac{25}{x}$ on $]0, +\infty[$.

Textbook references

Further practice: Calao, course pp. 88–93; exercises p. 94, no. 1–5. The application exercise below is original; these references point to textbook exercises for extra practice and for its figures.

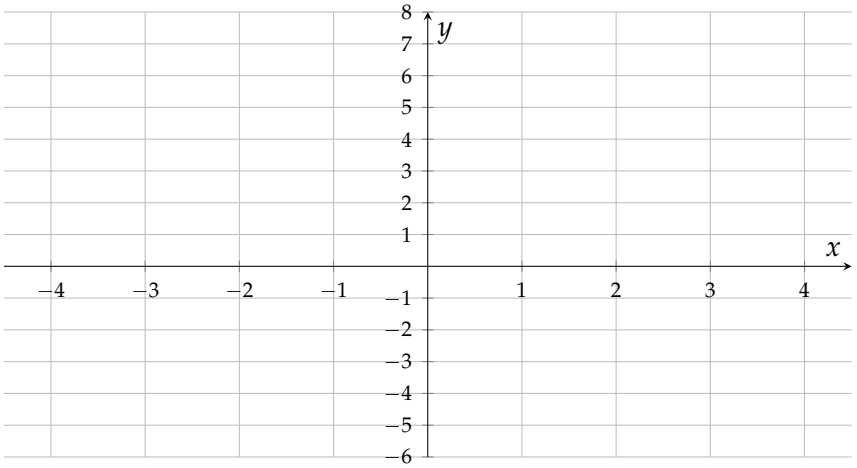
Application exercise

Consider the functions f and g defined on $\mathbb{R}^* = \mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$ by $f(x) = -\dfrac{2}{x}$ and $g(x) = 1 + \dfrac{3}{x}$.

1. Explain why 0 does not belong to the domain of these functions.
2. Complete the table of values (values rounded to the nearest hundredth if necessary).

x	-4	-3	-2	-1	-0.5	0.5	1	2	3	4
$f(x)$										
$g(x)$										

3. Plot the points and draw the curves $\mathcal{C}_f$ and $\mathcal{C}_g$ on the grid below.



4. Show that, for every non-zero real x, $f(-x) = -f(x)$. Which symmetry of $\mathcal{C}_f$ does this express? For each curve, give the lines it gets closer and closer to (asymptotes).

Homework

Redo practice exercise 2 with the following data: replace the initial value by 235 and the rate or common ratio by 7. Write it up in four lines: data, formula, calculation, conclusion.

Exit ticket – 3 minutes

On a half-sheet: write the main rule of the session, work through a very short example and state your confidence level from 1 to 4. Key question(s) of the day: 1, 2 and 3.

Session 24 — Behaviour at the boundaries and asymptotes

Reciprocal (inverse) function

17 Dec 2026 • B: 1 h – C: 2 h

Session objectives

- Describe the behaviour at the boundaries.
- Identify the asymptotes.
- Read a graph.

Fluency – 6 to 8 minutes, no calculator

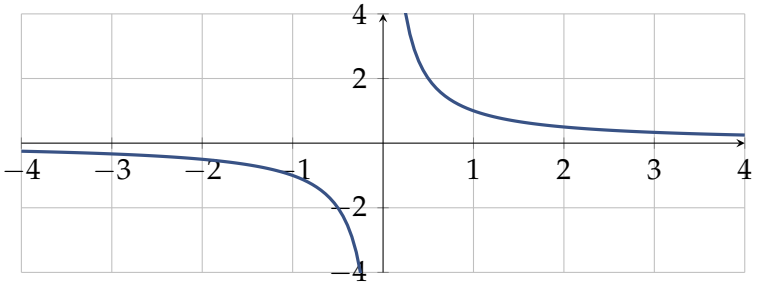
1. Calculate 5 % of 120. .....
2. Calculate $\frac{1}{6}$ and $\frac{1}{-6}$. .....
3. Differentiate $3x^2 - 5x + 1$. .....
4. Solve $(x-2)(x+1) = 0$. .....
5. Give the excluded value of $\frac{x+1}{x}$. .....

Reminder and prerequisites

Reread the last written record and be able to carry out the basic calculations needed today. Before the investigation, have students rephrase the key words: describe the behaviour at the boundaries and identify the asymptotes.

Investigation

Using a table of values near 0 and for large values of $|x|$, describe $\frac{1}{x}$. Translate each behaviour into an asymptote and a sentence.



Written record

For $f(x) = \frac{1}{x}$, $x = 0$ is a vertical asymptote and $y = 0$ a horizontal asymptote. The branches approach them without crossing them.

Worked example

Revisit the data from the investigation and write up the solution in order: definition of the objects, property used, exact or approximate calculation, then a concluding sentence. The model answer

appears in the teacher edition.

Practice – essential

1. Give the domain and the asymptotes of $f(x) = 6 + \dfrac{8}{x}$.
2. Calculate $f'(x)$ and study its sign.
3. Study the function $g(x) = x + \dfrac{36}{x}$ on $]0, +\infty[$.

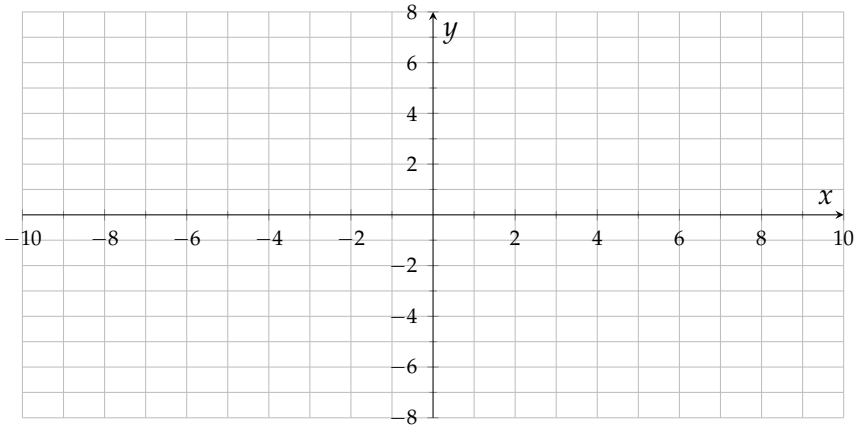
Textbook references

Further practice: Calao, course pp. 88–93; exercises p. 94, no. 4–9. The application exercise below is original; these references point to textbook exercises for extra practice and for its figures.

Application exercise

Let h be the function defined on $\mathbb{R}^*$ by $h(x) = -1 + \dfrac{5}{x}$.

1. Compute $h(x)$ for $x \in \{-10\,000; -1\,000; -100; 100; 1\,000; 10\,000\}$. What can be conjectured about $h(x)$ when x becomes very large in absolute value? Which asymptote can be deduced?
2. Compute $h(x)$ for $x \in \{-0.1; -0.01; -0.001; 0.001; 0.01; 0.1\}$. Describe the behaviour of $h(x)$ when x gets close to 0, first through negative values, then through positive values. Which asymptote can be deduced?
3. Compute $h(-5)$, $h(-1)$, $h(1)$ and $h(5)$, then sketch the curve of h and its asymptotes on the grid below.



4. Application. A training organisation rents a room for 450 € per day and spends 12 € on meals per participant. For x participants ($x \geqslant 1$), the average cost per participant is $c(x) = 12 + \dfrac{450}{x}$ (in euros).
   a. Compute $c(10)$, $c(50)$ and $c(150)$.
   b. Which value does the average cost get closer to when the number of participants becomes very large? Can it fall below 12 €? Justify.

Homework

Redo practice exercise 3 with the following data: replace the initial value by 240 and the rate or common ratio by 2. Write it up in four lines: data, formula, calculation, conclusion.

Exit ticket – 3 minutes

On a half-sheet: write the main rule of the session, work through a very short example and state your confidence level from 1 to 4. Key question(s) of the day: 1 and 2.

Session 25 — Derivative and direction of variation

Reciprocal (inverse) function

5 Jan 2027 • B: 2 h – C: 1 h

Session objectives

- Differentiate the reciprocal function.
- Justify the variations.
- Draw up a table.

Fluency – 6 to 8 minutes, no calculator

1. Write the multiplier for an increase of 10 %. .....
2. Differentiate $3x^2 - 5x + 1$. .....
3. Solve $(x-2)(x+1) = 0$. .....
4. Give the excluded value of $\dfrac{x+1}{x}$. .....
5. Calculate $\dfrac{1}{7}$ and $\dfrac{1}{-7}$. .....

Reminder and prerequisites

Reread the last written record and be able to carry out the basic calculations needed today. Before the investigation, have students rephrase the key words: differentiate the reciprocal function and justify the variations.

Investigation

Starting from the difference quotient of $f(x) = \dfrac{1}{x}$, recover $f'(x) = -\dfrac{1}{x^2}$. Study its sign and check consistency with the graph.

Written record

For $x \neq 0$, $f'(x) = -\dfrac{1}{x^2} < 0$. The reciprocal function decreases on each of the intervals $]-\infty, 0[$ and $]0, +\infty[$.

Worked example

Revisit the data from the investigation and write up the solution in order: definition of the objects, property used, exact or approximate calculation, then a concluding sentence. The model answer appears in the teacher edition.

Practice – essential

1. Give the domain and the asymptotes of $f(x) = 2 + \dfrac{4}{x}$.
2. Calculate $f'(x)$ and study its sign.
3. Study the function $g(x) = x + \dfrac{4}{x}$ on $]0, +\infty[$.

Textbook references

Further practice: Calao, course pp. 89–93; exercises p. 94, no. 1–3, then p. 96, no. 10–13. The application exercise below is original; these references point to textbook exercises for extra practice and for its figures.

Application exercise

Compute the derivative of each of the following functions, defined on $\mathbb{R}^*$.

a. $f(x) = 5x + 2 - \dfrac{3}{x}$

b. $g(x) = -4x + 7 + \dfrac{6}{x}$

c. $h(x) = 2x^3 - 5x^2 + \dfrac{1}{x}$

d. $k(x) = \dfrac{1}{2}x^2 + 4x - \dfrac{8}{x}$

e. $p(x) = \dfrac{x^2 + 2}{x}$ (first write $p(x)$ in the form $x + \dfrac{a}{x}$, then give $p'(x)$ as a single quotient)

Homework

Redo practice exercise 2 with the following data: replace the initial value by 245 and the rate or common ratio by 3. Write it up in four lines: data, formula, calculation, conclusion.

Exit ticket – 3 minutes

On a half-sheet: write the main rule of the session, work through a very short example and state your confidence level from 1 to 4. Key question(s) of the day: 1, 2 and 3.

Session 26 — Combinations with polynomial functions

Reciprocal (inverse) function

7 Jan 2027 • B: 1 h – C: 2 h

Session objectives

- Differentiate a combination of functions.
- Simplify an expression.
- Organise a function study.

Fluency – 6 to 8 minutes, no calculator

1. Simplify $3x + 8 - x + 2$. .....
2. Solve $(x - 2)(x + 1) = 0$. .....
3. Give the excluded value of $\dfrac{x+1}{x}$. .....
4. Calculate $\dfrac{1}{8}$ and $\dfrac{1}{-8}$. .....
5. Differentiate $3x^2 - 5x + 1$. .....

Reminder and prerequisites

Reread the last written record and be able to carry out the basic calculations needed today. Before the investigation, have students rephrase the key words: differentiate a combination of functions and simplify an expression.

Investigation

A company produces $x > 0$ hundred items and its average cost is $C(x) = 2x + 30 + \dfrac{200}{x}$. Calculate $C'(x)$, factorise its numerator and find the production level that minimises the average cost.

Written record

To study $P(x) + \dfrac{k}{x}$, find the domain, calculate the derivative, put over a common denominator, study its sign, then draw up the variations.

Worked example

Revisit the data from the investigation and write up the solution in order: definition of the objects, property used, exact or approximate calculation, then a concluding sentence. The model answer appears in the teacher edition.

Practice – essential

1. Give the domain and the asymptotes of $f(x) = 3 + \dfrac{5}{x}$.
2. Calculate $f'(x)$ and study its sign.
3. Study the function $g(x) = x + \dfrac{9}{x}$ on $]0, +\infty[$.

Textbook references

Further practice: Calao, p. 96, no. 14–21. The application exercise below is original; these references point to textbook exercises for extra practice and for its figures.

Application exercise

Let f be the function defined on $\mathbb{R}^*$ by $f(x) = 9x - 2 + \dfrac{4}{x}$.

1. Show that, for every non-zero real x, $f'(x) = \dfrac{(3x-2)(3x+2)}{x^2}$.
2. Study the sign of $f'(x)$ on $\mathbb{R}^*$ using a sign table.
3. Deduce the table of variations of f, including the values of $f\left(-\dfrac{2}{3}\right)$ and $f\left(\dfrac{2}{3}\right)$.
4. Compare $f\left(-\dfrac{2}{3}\right)$ and $f\left(\dfrac{2}{3}\right)$. Can a local maximum be less than a local minimum? Explain using the table.

Homework

Redo practice exercise 3 with the following data: replace the initial value by 250 and the rate or common ratio by 4. Write it up in four lines: data, formula, calculation, conclusion.

Exit ticket – 3 minutes

On a half-sheet: write the main rule of the session, work through a very short example and state your confidence level from 1 to 4. Key question(s) of the day: 1 and 2.

Session 27 — Sign and factorisation

Reciprocal (inverse) function

12 Jan 2027 • B: 2 h – C: 1 h

Session objectives

- Factorise.
- Build a sign table.
- Respect excluded values.

Fluency – 6 to 8 minutes, no calculator

1. Calculate 20 % of 180. .....
2. Give the excluded value of $\dfrac{x+1}{x}$. .....
3. Calculate $\dfrac{1}{9}$ and $\dfrac{1}{-9}$. .....
4. Differentiate $3x^2 - 5x + 1$. .....
5. Solve $(x-2)(x+1) = 0$. .....

Reminder and prerequisites

Reread the last written record and be able to carry out the basic calculations needed today. Before the investigation, have students rephrase the key words: factorise and build a sign table.

Investigation

Study the sign of $\dfrac{(x-2)(x+3)}{x}$. Build the table with the three critical values, distinguish a zero from an excluded value, then solve the inequality $\dfrac{(x-2)(x+3)}{x} \geq 0$.

Written record

In a quotient, the sign depends on the numerator and the denominator. Excluded values are left out of the table, even if a factor formally cancels.

Worked example

Revisit the data from the investigation and write up the solution in order: definition of the objects, property used, exact or approximate calculation, then a concluding sentence. The model answer appears in the teacher edition.

Practice – essential

1. Give the domain and the asymptotes of $f(x) = 4 + \dfrac{6}{x}$.
2. Calculate $f'(x)$ and study its sign.
3. Study the function $g(x) = x + \dfrac{16}{x}$ on $]0, +\infty[$.

Textbook references

Further practice: Calao, pp. 96–101. The application exercise below is original; these references point to textbook exercises for extra practice and for its figures.

Application exercise

Let h be the function defined on $\mathbb{R}^*$ by $h(x) = 2x - 3 - \dfrac{5}{x}$.

1. Show that, for every non-zero real x, $h'(x) = \dfrac{2x^2 + 5}{x^2}$.
2. Study the sign of $h'(x)$ and deduce the variations of h.
3. Compute $h(-1)$ and $h(1)$. Can we say that "h is increasing on $\mathbb{R}^*$"? Explain.
4. Show that, for every non-zero real x, $h(x) = \dfrac{(2x-5)(x+1)}{x}$. Draw the sign table of $h(x)$, then solve the inequality $h(x) \geqslant 0$.

Homework

Redo practice exercise 2 with the following data: replace the initial value by 255 and the rate or common ratio by 5. Write it up in four lines: data, formula, calculation, conclusion.

Exit ticket – 3 minutes

On a half-sheet: write the main rule of the session, work through a very short example and state your confidence level from 1 to 4. Key question(s) of the day: 1, 2 and 3.

Session 28 — Derivatives of polynomials of degree at most 3

Reciprocal (inverse) function

14 Jan 2027 • B: 1 h – C: 2 h

Session objectives

- Differentiate a polynomial.
- Study a derivative.
- Deduce the variations.

Fluency – 6 to 8 minutes, no calculator

1. Write the multiplier for an increase of 25 %. .....
2. Calculate $\frac{1}{3}$ and $\frac{1}{-3}$. .....
3. Differentiate $3x^2 - 5x + 1$. .....
4. Solve $(x-2)(x+1) = 0$. .....
5. Give the excluded value of $\frac{x+1}{x}$. .....

Reminder and prerequisites

Reread the last written record and be able to carry out the basic calculations needed today. Before the investigation, have students rephrase the key words: differentiate a polynomial and study a derivative.

Investigation

For $f(x) = 2x^3 - 3x^2 - 12x + 5$, calculate $f'(x)$, factorise, study its sign and deduce the variations of f.

Written record

$(ax^3 + bx^2 + cx + d)' = 3ax^2 + 2bx + c$. The sign of the derivative gives the direction of variation of the function.

Worked example

Revisit the data from the investigation and write up the solution in order: definition of the objects, property used, exact or approximate calculation, then a concluding sentence. The model answer appears in the teacher edition.

Practice – essential

1. Give the domain and the asymptotes of $f(x) = 5 + \frac{7}{x}$.
2. Calculate $f'(x)$ and study its sign.
3. Study the function $g(x) = x + \frac{25}{x}$ on $]0, +\infty[$.

Textbook references

Further practice: Calao, pp. 94–96. The application exercise below is original; these references point to textbook exercises for extra practice and for its figures.

Application exercise

Let f be the reciprocal function, defined on $\mathbb{R}^*$ by $f(x) = \dfrac{1}{x}$.

1. Let h be a non-zero real number, with $h \neq -2$. Show that the rate of change of f between 2 and $2+h$ is $\dfrac{f(2+h)-f(2)}{h} = -\dfrac{1}{2(2+h)}$. Letting h tend to 0, deduce $f'(2)$.

2. We admit that, for every non-zero real x, $f'(x) = -\dfrac{1}{x^2}$. Check consistency with question 1, then compute $f'(-1)$ and $f'(0.5)$.

3. Study the sign of $f'(x)$ and draw the table of variations of f.

4. A student notices that $-2 < 3$ and $f(-2) < f(3)$, and claims that this contradicts the fact that f is decreasing. What should we answer?

Homework

Redo practice exercise 3 with the following data: replace the initial value by 260 and the rate or common ratio by 6. Write it up in four lines: data, formula, calculation, conclusion.

Exit ticket – 3 minutes

On a half-sheet: write the main rule of the session, work through a very short example and state your confidence level from 1 to 4. Key question(s) of the day: 1 and 2.

Session 29 — Full study and graph

Reciprocal (inverse) function

19 Jan 2027 • B: 2 h – C: 1 h

Session objectives

- Carry out a full study.
- Draw a consistent curve.
- Interpret an extremum.

Fluency – 6 to 8 minutes, no calculator

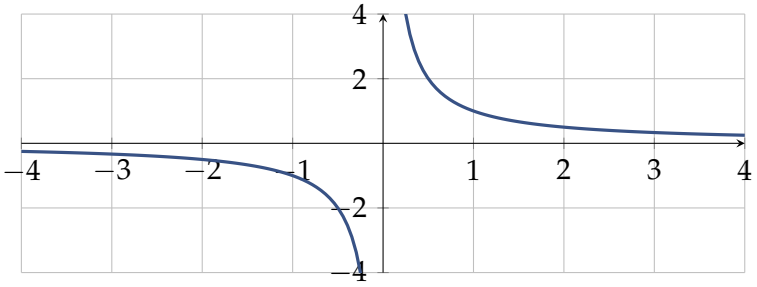
1. Simplify $3x + 4 - x + 2$. .....
2. Differentiate $3x^2 - 5x + 1$. .....
3. Solve $(x - 2)(x + 1) = 0$. .....
4. Give the excluded value of $\dfrac{x+1}{x}$. .....
5. Calculate $\dfrac{1}{4}$ and $\dfrac{1}{-4}$. .....

Reminder and prerequisites

Reread the last written record and be able to carry out the basic calculations needed today. Before the investigation, have students rephrase the key words: carry out a full study and draw a consistent curve.

Investigation

Study $g(x) = x + \dfrac{9}{x}$ completely on $]0, +\infty[$: domain, derivative, sign, variations, minimum, behaviour at the boundaries and sketch.



Written record

A full study includes: domain, derivative, sign, variations, limits or behaviour at the boundaries, key points and a consistent graph.

Worked example

Revisit the data from the investigation and write up the solution in order: definition of the objects, property used, exact or approximate calculation, then a concluding sentence. The model answer appears in the teacher edition.

Practice – essential

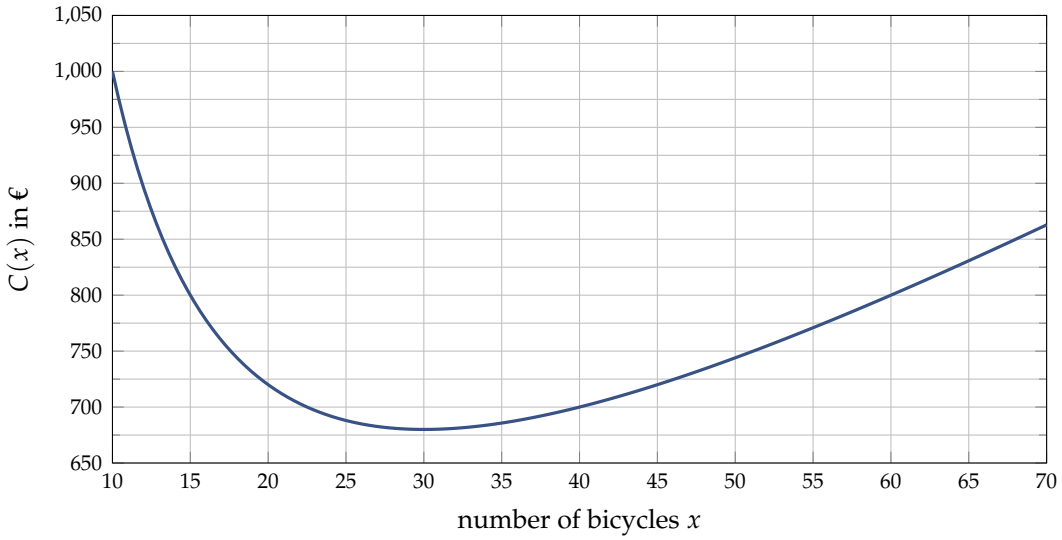
1. Give the domain and the asymptotes of $f(x) = 6 + \dfrac{8}{x}$.
2. Calculate $f'(x)$ and study its sign.
3. Study the function $g(x) = x + \dfrac{36}{x}$ on $]0, +\infty[$.

Textbook references

Further practice: Calao, pp. 98–103. The application exercise below is original; these references point to textbook exercises for extra practice and for its figures.

Application exercise

A company assembles between 10 and 70 electric bicycles per month. For x bicycles assembled, let $C(x)$ be the average unit production cost, in euros. The curve of the function C on $[10;70]$ is given below.



1. Read the average unit cost when the company assembles 15 bicycles, then 50 bicycles.
2. For which production levels is the average unit cost equal to 800 €?
3. What is the minimum average unit cost? For which production level is it reached?
4. We admit that $C(x) = 8x + 200 + \dfrac{7\,200}{x}$. Compute $C'(x)$, check that $C'(x) = \dfrac{8(x-30)(x+30)}{x^2}$ and confirm the answer to question 3 by calculation.

Homework

Redo practice exercise 2 with the following data: replace the initial value by 265 and the rate or common ratio by 7. Write it up in four lines: data, formula, calculation, conclusion.

Exit ticket – 3 minutes

On a half-sheet: write the main rule of the session, work through a very short example and state your confidence level from 1 to 4. Key question(s) of the day: 1, 2 and 3.

Session 30 — Review and assessment

Reciprocal (inverse) function

21 Jan 2027 • B: 1 h – C: 2 h

Session objectives

- Use domain, derivative and sign.
- Write up a study.
- Correct work methodically.

Fluency – 6 to 8 minutes, no calculator

1. Calculate 5 % of 100. .....
2. Solve $(x-2)(x+1)=0$. .....
3. Give the excluded value of $\dfrac{x+1}{x}$. .....
4. Calculate $\dfrac{1}{5}$ and $\dfrac{1}{-5}$. .....
5. Differentiate $3x^2-5x+1$. .....

Reminder and prerequisites

Reread the last written record and be able to carry out the basic calculations needed today. Before the investigation, have students rephrase the key words: use domain, derivative and sign and write up a study.

Investigation

Correct a deliberately flawed study of $h(x)=x+\dfrac{4}{x}$: stated domain $\mathbb{R}$, derivative $1+\dfrac{4}{x^2}$, table with no break at 0. Rewrite a complete solution.

Written record

Check the four items separately: domain, expression of the derivative, sign of the derivative, variations. An error at one step must not hide the following ones.

Worked example

Revisit the data from the investigation and write up the solution in order: definition of the objects, property used, exact or approximate calculation, then a concluding sentence. The model answer appears in the teacher edition.

Practice – essential

1. Give the domain and the asymptotes of $f(x)=2+\dfrac{4}{x}$.
2. Calculate $f'(x)$ and study its sign.
3. Study the function $g(x)=x+\dfrac{4}{x}$ on $]0,+\infty[$.

Textbook references

Further practice: Calao, pp. 100–103. The application exercise below is original; these references point to textbook exercises for extra practice and for its figures.

Application exercise

A composting site produces x tonnes of compost each week, with $x \in [2;25]$. The total weekly production cost, in euros, is modelled by $C(x) = 2x^2 + 40x + 288$. Let f be the function giving the average production cost of one tonne: $f(x) = \dfrac{C(x)}{x}$.

1. Show that, for every $x \in [2;25]$, $f(x) = 2x + 40 + \dfrac{288}{x}$.
2. Compute $f'(x)$ and show that, for every $x \in [2;25]$, $f'(x) = \dfrac{2(x-12)(x+12)}{x^2}$.
3. Study the sign of $f'(x)$ on $[2;25]$ and draw the table of variations of f (including the values at the endpoints).
4. What is the minimum average cost of one tonne of compost? For which weekly production is it reached? What is the total cost of the week then?

Homework

Redo practice exercise 3 with the following data: replace the initial value by 270 and the rate or common ratio by 2. Write it up in four lines: data, formula, calculation, conclusion.

Exit ticket – 3 minutes

On a half-sheet: write the main rule of the session, work through a very short example and state your confidence level from 1 to 4. Key question(s) of the day: 1 and 2.